



ANIL SHINDE

The people have lost faith in more than just the judiciary. When Bihar Chief Minister Nitish Kumar held his last janata durbar, 1,600 people turned up to complain about police inaction. In West Bengal's southern districts, people have not received any rations for 11 months. When an angry group turned up at an all-party meeting in Labhpur in Birbhum district in the hope of redressal, they were turned away. Himingshu Das was one of the mob that torched a police jeep and tried to set other government vehicles in Labhpur ablaze. He said, "We are starving and the administration is not ready to listen to us... we faced a combat force, lathicharge and tear gas and still we do not get our rations. What should we do?"

Thane, Maharashtra **A MAID-UP STORY**

"A majority of mob protests have ulterior motives and a lot of them are politically motivated."

B.K. SONAWANE, ACP, THANE

On August 21, around 100 people barged into Prakash Shetty's home and beat him up after his maid Lakshmibai Shinde accused him of molestation and assault. This turned out to be a staged incident, sparked by a dispute. All the domestic maids involved were sacked.

punished quickly. Dulal Chandra Dey, IGP of the Rapid Action Force that was set up in the 1990s to deal only with communal violence, now finds the force being sent out to deal with urban unrest, conventionally the business of the local police. He says the incidents reflect "a general degradation in society and an impatience with the slow pace of the criminal justice system. People these days want instant justice."

Given the pace at which India's courts work, instant justice seems a contradiction in terms, speedy justice

an impossibility. Indian courts today face a backlog of more than 2.59 crore pending cases and a shortage of 3,000 judges—its impact is now being felt on the street. Dispensing a 50-year-old case recently and taking note of the Vaishali lynching, Justice A.K. Mathur and Justice Markandey Katju of the Supreme Court said, "This is obviously because many people have started thinking that justice will not be done due to delay in court proceedings... people in this country are fast losing faith in the judiciary."

The perpetrators of mob violence come in many guises. In Edappal, Kerala, the attackers of the pregnant woman were between 20-25 years old with no criminal records, two of them worked in the store where the shopper raised the alarm. According to West Bengal's Food Minister Paresch Adhikari, a section of businessmen are inciting the ration riots, with mostly middle class people involved in looting. The fake sting on Delhi school teacher Uma Khurana was allegedly masterminded by local businessman Virendra Arora to settle an old score.

Asha Bajpai, professor of socio-legal studies at the Tata Institute of Social Sciences in Mumbai, makes a distinction in mob violence. One kind erupts when, "people feel no one is lis-

"Our people should be willing to approach a policeman with the same assurance with which they visit a doctor."

MANMOHAN SINGH, PRIME MINISTER

